missile detachments had made their way to Cuba secretly, via Conakry and Bermuda, Mikoyan traveled openly, with the Americans hoping no less than the Soviets for the success of his diplomatic skills. On November 1, the day he landed in New York, Mikoyan met with U Thant and had dinner with two Americans directly dealing with the Cuban crisis, the US representative to the UN, Adlai Stevenson, and the chairman of the Council on Foreign Relations and Kennedy's point man for Cuba, John McCloy.[4]

The Americans knew Mikoyan from his visit to the United States in 1960, and the meeting around the dinner table lasted for four hours, from 7:00 to 11:00 p.m. A number of Soviet officials took part, including the deputy foreign minister, Vasilii Kuznetsov, and the Soviet ambassadors to the US, Anatoly Dobrynin, and to the UN, Valerian Zorin. "Mikoyan started in [an] aggressive mood, insisting on suspending quarantine now," reported Stevenson to Washington. Khrushchev's envoy was following the latest instructions he had just received from Moscow but did not get very far, as Stevenson and McCloy told him that there would be no lifting of the quarantine until the Red Cross could inspect Soviet ships. "Meeting became more cordial and friendly as it proceeded and was exclusively dominated by Mikoyan," wrote Stevenson in his report.[5]

According to Mikoyan, who filed his own report about the dinner, Stevenson and McCloy were largely interested in verifying the withdrawal of Soviet missiles from Cuba. They made it clear that the United States would not sign a joint protocol guaranteeing not to invade Cuba if Cuba was also a signatory of such a document, but they were allegedly open to the idea that guarantees would be given as part of a package of documents including American, Soviet, and even Cuban official statements. In his report, Stevenson denied ever agreeing to Cuba's participation. But that was something that Mikoyan wanted to take with him to Havana to appease Castro. Stevenson and McCloy, wrote Mikoyan in his report to Moscow, "stated that the US refused pointblank to discuss the question of liquidating the American base in Guantánamo." That was one of Castro's five points for the resolution of the crisis, and the American refusal to discuss it even as a possibility promised nothing good for Mikoyan's mission in Havana.

On the issue of verifying the withdrawal of Soviet missiles, which was paramount for Stevenson and McCloy, both men fully realized the